

Feedback from Week 2



THE LONDON SCHOOL
OF ECONOMICS AND
POLITICAL SCIENCE ■

Understanding the question



Last week you had two questions to answer:

1. What are gender stereotypes?
 2. Why do they persist?
- Did you spend an equal amount of your essay answering each question?
 - Some essays were divided equally between the questions.
 - The best essays spent more time on the second question (more analytical) than the first question (more descriptive).

Last week, we discussed how to ‘synthesise’ literature in your writing. In other words, how to combine multiple sources to create a coherent new whole.

How did you do in this area?

- Do you cite all three of the extracts?
- How many citations do you have in each paragraph?
- Do you show relationships between the extracts – e.g. do you compare and contrast them or draw other links?

Citations



- Prentice, D. A., & Carranza, E. (2002). What women and men should be, shouldn't be, are allowed to be, and don't have to be: The contents of prescriptive gender stereotypes. *Psychology of women quarterly*, 26(4), 269-281
- (Prentice & Carranza, 2002) or Prentice and Carranza (2002)
- Ellemers, N. (2018). Gender stereotypes. *Annual review of psychology*, 69(1), 275-298.
- (Ellemers, 2018)
- Haines, E. L., Deaux, K., & Lofaro, N. (2016). The times they are a-changing... or are they not? A comparison of gender stereotypes, 1983–2014. *Psychology of Women Quarterly*, 40(3), 353-363.
- Haines et al (2016)

Secondary Citations



There were a few mistakes here. For example, we didn't read Bem (1974) so, instead of saying: Bem (1974) found...It should be: Bem (1974, cited in Prentice & Carranza, 2002) found...

This is a good example of secondary citation:

- “According to Bem (1974, cited in Haines et al, 2016), feminine characteristics are related to emotions and tenderness, while masculine characteristics are associated with leadership and independence. Similarly, Deaux and Lewis (1983, cited in Haines et al, 2016) also suggested that social gender stereotypes linked agency with males, whilst community with females.”

Using the texts



- Synthesizing the texts was a bit challenging this week
- ‘Reading frames’ like the ones on the next slide can be useful
- Do try to create your own ‘narrative’ or argument; quite a few people just summarised the arguments laid out in Extracts 2 & 3.

What are gender stereotypes?



Prentice & Carranza, 2002	(Ellemers, 2018)	Haines et al (2016)
• Highly prescriptive qualities prescribed to men & women e.g. women are warm & caring; men are strong & agentic.		• Linked to social roles as well as traits

Why do gender stereotypes persist?



Prentice & Carranza, 2002	(Ellemers, 2018)	Haines et al (2016)
• Linked to power inequalities • Violations are met with 'various forms of punishment & devaluation'	• Mostly implicitly • Education • Media representations • Verbal accounts • Non-verbal communications • Emotions	• Confirmation bias • Backlash • Cultural lag • Essentialist categorical beliefs

You didn't need to include all this information

Talking about theory...



- Haines et al (2016) cite various reasons for gender stereotypes persisting. For example, 'confirmation bias and self-fulfilling prophecies' and 'backlash and status incongruity theory'.
- Don't 'name-drop' – only refer to the theories if you understand them and can demonstrate that through an explanation of the theory and/or examples.

Thesis Statement – address both parts of the essay question



What are gender stereotypes and why do they persist?

Gender stereotypes have been identified and analysed by many scholars over the years. This essay will firstly examine some examples of gender stereotypes and then suggest reasons of their persistence. This essay contends that gender stereotypes are some generalised typical traits, social roles, work and characteristics of men and women which are considered to be socially desirable for them but are not necessarily true, and they seem to persist due to confirmation bias, disadvantage on non-stereotypical activities, and essentialist categorical beliefs (Hines et al., 2016), which are unconsciously influenced by various factors from their early stage of life.

Provide some context for the essay topic in your introduction, but avoid making overly generalized claims that you cannot support with evidence



In the last decades, Gender equality has been a thorny issue that humankind has grappled with. There are several points of view about how this issue has evolved. Some people argue that gender inequality has been decreasing, other people suggest that on the contrary, inequality in gender has arisen, and even some people suggest that there is not a gender inequality problem. This ambivalence has made the academic sector gets interested in finding out reasons to understand the different interpretation about gender equality. One of them might be associated with the stereotypes of genders and how people use them to determine whether the level of gender equality. Therefore, this essay will try to contribute to this debate by analyzing the question, What are gender stereotypes and why do they persist?

Sample introduction



Gender stereotypes, which define women as warm and caring and men as strong and agentic, are deeply-rooted in society. These stereotypes are associated with traditional social roles and power imbalances, reinforcing stereotypes about how men and women should behave. This essay will explore these stereotypes, highlighting the role of parenting, media, body language, and emotions in maintaining them. It will also examine how stereotypes extend beyond traits to social roles and occupations, and why they persist despite changing gender roles.

Sample introduction



Gender stereotypes have become an increasingly thorny issue in recent social movements for gender equality and the psychology of gender. In recent years, a number of researchers have discussed the contents of gender stereotypes and how these gender concepts function continuously on women and men's self-consciousness or the societal expectations. To be specific, the idea of changing the highly stereotyped status quo of gender roles from the aspect of occupations in the homes, workplace and sports has been expected by the Social Representation Theory (Eagly, 1987; Croft et al., 1987, cited from Haines et al., 2016). Unfortunately, no evidence of substantial stereotype change has been found yet (Haines et al., 2016), for the strong durability of these stereotyping beliefs has deeply rooted. This essay will highlight the prescriptive contents of gender stereotypes and the reasons of the durability of gender stereotypes in the context of gender psychology. The essay will first discuss the definition of gender stereotypes and the description of gender stereotyping. Then, the reasons of persisting stereotypes will be outlined through the discussion of the mechanism of gender stereotypes.

Avoid being “overly descriptive” of one text (using one text per paragraph) / close paraphrasing



As for the persistence of gender stereotypes, there are several reasons. Firstly, gender stereotypes are related to social expectations and beliefs. Gender stereotypes are closely linked to traditional social roles and power inequalities between women and men (Eagly, 1987; Prentice and Carranza, 2002). It prescribes individuals' behaviors and values.

Secondly, education affects children's views on gender and it makes the views unchangeable. Endendijk et al. 2014; Ellemers (2018) claim that education conveys what children consider to be appropriate behaviors and activities for boys and girls by making more positive comments about images of children engaging in gender stereotyping. This shows the difficulty of improving stereotypes of adults.

* Highlighted by TurnItIn

Instead, try to create synthesis by linking ideas from the texts



According to Deaux and Lewis's (1983, cited in Haines et al., 2016) examination, gender stereotypes include beliefs that males and females have different characteristics, social roles, occupations and physical traits. Bem (1974, cited in Prentice & Carranza, 2002) also suggested there are typically desirable characteristics for both men and women in society. Determined traits for Females were related to being caring and warm, and Male traits were related to being strong and agentic. Moreover, those traits matched societal prescriptions (Eagly, 1987, cited in Pretice & Carranza, 2002).

As shown above, dramatic change in gender stereotypes have never detected in the last few decades, although the actual roles and behaviors between men and women have become more and more similar (Haines et al, 2016). The resilience of stereotypes comes from the following three reasons. First cause is its prescriptive characteristic. As gender stereotypes reflect and justified by traditional gender roles and power inequalities (Eagly, 1987, cited by Prentice & Carranza, 2002). Because of its prescriptive aspect, violation of gender stereotypes will result in punishment and devaluation (Fiske et al, 1991; Rudman & Glick 1999, cited by Prentice & Carranza, 2002). Thus, especially women could not choose to resist gender stereotypes.

...and combine evidence from the text with your own voice



Gender stereotypes are societal opinions which show the personality traits, social roles and occupations of masculinity and femininity, and these opinions tend to follow the conventional concepts of most people. According to gender stereotypes, feminine characteristics are: affectionate, cheerful, warm and caring; while masculine characteristics are: acts as a leader, strong and agentic (Prentice and Carranza, 2002). Additionally, verbal accounts that are commonly noticed in daily lives can also show gender stereotypes. For instance, when evaluating men, words like talent, genius and brilliant are often used, whereas words like hardworking, conscientious and dependable are often used when evaluating women (Ellemers, 2018). Therefore, gender stereotypes are the societal opinions that can affect the description of the images of masculinity and femininity.

Sample main body paragraph



Generally speaking, stereotypes are societal prescriptions (Prentice/Carranza, 2002) for social roles, occupations and physical characteristics (Haines et al., 2016). Gender stereotypes are associated with traditional stereotypic beliefs, like that feminine characteristics are weakness and loyalty and masculine characteristics are independence and individualism (Prentice/Carranza, 2002). It is believed that gender stereotypes have their origins in traditional social roles and power inequalities between women and men (Ellemers, 2018; Prentice/Carranza, 2002). Furthermore, gender stereotypes are influenced by education, the media and communication (Ellemers, 2018). As a result, gender stereotypes have a significant role in justifying and perpetuating the status quo (Prentice/Carranza, 2002).

Sample main body paragraph



Last but not least, existing economic and power structures maintain gender stereotypes. Historically, men held the majority of power in political, economic, and social spheres, which is evident in leadership positions, property ownership, and decision-making roles, where men dominated the key institutions that shaped society. This concentration of power led to the creation and enforcement of laws, policies, and cultural norms that favored men and limited opportunities for women. For example, in many societies, women were denied the right to vote, own property, or work in certain professions. In consequence, those who hold power within these structures may resist changes that threaten their dominance. Efforts to promote gender equality, such as affirmative action, gender quotas, or family-friendly workplace policies, can be met with resistance from those who benefit from the status quo.

Sample conclusion



In conclusion, gender stereotypes, though originally intended for positive purposes, have evolved into tools that reinforce power imbalances and restrict both women and men. This essay has explored their historical and sociological roots, showing how traditional roles, media, and family dynamics sustain these stereotypes (Deaux & Lewis, 1983, cited by Haines et al., 2016). To achieve greater gender equity, it is essential to challenge these enduring stereotypes and encourage individuals to transcend limiting societal expectations.

Note:



What (if anything) is the difference between:

- An essay
- An article
- A dissertation
- A paper

Note:



What (if anything) is the difference between:

- An essay: this is something you are likely to write at LSE; the word 'essay' comes from the French 'essayer' meaning 'to try'; an essay is an attempt (try) to understand a subject.
- An article: this is piece of writing that has been published in a journal, magazine, newspaper, blog....
- A dissertation: this is a longer piece of writing (usually 10,000 words at LSE) and typically involves researching a question.
- A paper: this can be an umbrella term for an essay or article; it isn't a term that is widely used in the UK context.

Avoid clichés



- A clichés is a phrase or opinion that is overused and betrays a lack of original thought.
- Clichés can include expressions like ‘a double-edged sword’; ‘two sides of the same coin’; and ‘Pandora’s box’. These expressions are best avoided because they have lost their original impact.
- Clichés can also include expressions like ‘hotly contested’; ‘highly controversial’; ‘last but not least’ and ‘in a nutshell’. These expressions can be used but only if you do so in a meaningful way.
- In language exams, like IELTS, you are rewarded for being able to use idiomatic expressions. During your degree at LSE, content and clarity are important.

Try to avoid clichés and empty phrases...



Examples:

- X is a highly controversial issue
- X is a hotly contested issue
- A double-edged sword
- Two sides of the same coin
- In this day and age
- In today's society
- Throughout history
- There is a recent phenomenon that...
- Nowadays, X is receiving increasing attention
- X is widely discussed world-wide...

Some language points



- The term “social media” is both singular and plural in modern English usage.
- The word “media” is traditionally a plural because “medium” is the singular.
- However, in reference to things like the news media, social media, etc, the usage often becomes singular because ‘media’ is seen as a single unit.
- So, you can say ‘Social media has...’ or ‘Social media have...’ but, as always be consistent.

Some language points



When writing your essays, you might use collective nouns (like society, government, company, family, audience...)

- In American English, it's standard to treat collective nouns as singular.
- In British English, either way is acceptable:
 - The government is cutting back on public spending.
 - The government are cutting back on public spending.

(Note: In both American and British English, 'the police' always takes a plural form)

A bit of fun...

English has a lot of nouns to describe groups. You might be familiar with some of them e.g.,

- A crowd of
- A crowd of **people**
- A flock of....
- A flock of **sheep**
- A herd of...
- A herd of **cows**



Can you match these description?



- | | |
|--------------------|------------|
| 1. A murder of | a) Lions |
| 2. A school of | b) Geese |
| 3. A parliament of | c) Fish |
| 4. A troop of | d) Owls |
| 5. A colony of | e) Crows |
| 6. A pride of | f) Ants |
| 7. A gaggle of | g) Monkeys |

Can you match these description?



1. A murder of crows
2. A school of fish
3. A parliament of owls
4. A troop of monkeys
5. A colony of ants
6. A pride of lions
7. A gaggle of geese



A knot of toads



A bale of turtles



A nest of vipers



A culture of bacteria



A cloud of grasshoppers



A scourge of mosquitoes



A flight of butterflies



An army of caterpillars



An intrusion of cockroaches



A colony of ants



A swarm of bees



A clutter of spiders

Reading into Writing AI Feedback Workbook



Use your workbook for some additional feedback.



Once you have completed the workbook,
discuss:



1. Did you find the feedback useful?
2. What, if anything, have you learned?
3. Was there anything that surprised you?



Looking forward



What are your aims for this week? What areas do you want to improve?

